



# ELI — Using Ollama (Start to Finish)

ELI v2.4.79

September 2026

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## Using Ollama with ELI — a start-to-finish guide (no tech knowledge needed)

**Updated for v2.4.72.** The Ollama model picker in Settings / startup works on AppImage and portable builds (Qt compat shim exports QDialogButtonBox).

This guide is for anyone who wants ELI to use an **Ollama** model. You don't need to understand any of the words below — just follow the steps for your computer.

**The good news:** as of **v2.1.29**, if Ollama is installed on your machine, **ELI starts it for you automatically**. Most people don't have to do anything except install Ollama once and pick a model. The steps below cover installing it and what to do if anything doesn't work.

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### What is Ollama (in one sentence)?

Ollama is a free program that runs AI “brains” (models) on your own computer. ELI can borrow those brains instead of using its own. Everything stays on your machine.

**You do NOT need Ollama to use ELI** — ELI comes with its own brain. Ollama is only if you *want* to use models you've set up in Ollama.

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## Step 1 — Install Ollama (once)

Pick your computer:

### Windows

1. Go to **<https://ollama.com/download>** in your web browser.
2. Click **Download for Windows**, then run the file you downloaded.
3. Click through the installer (Next → Next → Finish). That's it — Ollama now starts automatically every time your computer turns on. You'll see a small llama icon near your clock.

### macOS (Apple computers)

1. Go to **<https://ollama.com/download>**.
2. Click **Download for macOS**, open the downloaded file, and drag **Ollama** into your Applications folder.
3. Open **Ollama** once from Applications. It runs quietly in the menu bar (top of your screen) from now on.

### Linux

1. Open a **Terminal**.
  2. Copy-paste this one line and press Enter:  

```
curl -fsSL https://ollama.com/install.sh | sh
```
  3. That installs Ollama and sets it to run in the background.
- 

## Step 2 — Get a model (once)

A model is the actual “brain”. You download one with a single command. Open a **Terminal** (macOS/Linux) or **Command Prompt / PowerShell** (Windows) and type:

```
ollama pull llama3.2
```

Wait for it to finish (it downloads a few gigabytes the first time). You can pull others later — `ollama pull qwen2.5`, `ollama pull mistral`, and so on. Browse them at **<https://ollama.com/library>**.

Tip: a smaller model like `llama3.2` or `qwen2.5:3b` is a good first choice — it loads faster and runs on modest computers.

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## Step 3 — Tell ELI to use Ollama

1. Start ELI. On the **first screen** (“Choose which model to load”), find the **Provider** dropdown near the top.
2. Choose **Ollama**.
3. In **Ollama model**, click **Refresh Ollama models** and pick the one you pulled in Step 2 (for example `llama3.2`).
4. Click **OK**.

That's it — ELI now thinks using your Ollama model.

You can also just **ask ELI** later: say or type “*switch to Ollama*” or “*use the llama3.2 model*”.

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## Step 4 — Change it whenever you like

- **In the app:** **Settings** → **Model** → **Backend** = **Ollama**, then **Refresh Ollama Models** and pick one.
  - **By talking to ELI:** “*use the mistral model*”, “*what Ollama models do I have*”.
  - **Back to ELI’s own brain:** set **Backend** to **Bundled** or **Custom GGUF**.
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## If something doesn’t work

ELI tries to start Ollama for you, so most problems fix themselves. If you still see “**Ollama unreachable**”:

- 1. Is Ollama installed?** Open a Terminal / Command Prompt and type `ollama list`. If it says *command not found*, go back to **Step 1**.
  - 2. Is a model downloaded?** If `ollama list` is empty, do **Step 2** (`ollama pull llama3.2`).
  - 3. Start it by hand (rarely needed):** - **Windows / macOS:** just open the **Ollama** app (Start menu / Applications). - **Linux:** type `systemctl --user start ollama` — or `ollama serve` and leave that window open.
  - 4. Ollama on a *different* computer (advanced):** You can point ELI at Ollama running on another machine on your home network. In **Ollama host**, type that machine’s address (e.g. 192.168.1.20 — you don’t need `http://` or a port, ELI fills those in). On that other machine, start Ollama with `OLLAMA_HOST=0.0.0.0:11434 ollama serve` and allow port 11434 through its firewall. ELI treats a machine you set here as trusted, so the Net toggle can stay **off**.
  - 5. Turn off auto-start (if you prefer):** ELI starting Ollama for you can be disabled by setting the environment variable `ELI_OLLAMA_AUTOSTART=0`.
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## The one-minute version

1. Install Ollama from <https://ollama.com/download> (once).
2. `ollama pull llama3.2` (once).
3. In ELI’s first screen: **Provider** → **Ollama** → **Refresh** → **pick your model** → **OK**.
4. ELI starts Ollama for you from then on. Done.